

## CHAPTER THREE

### Muslim Conquest: Bengal Sultanate

K M Mohsin

#### Society and Culture

**I**khhtiyaruddin Muhammad Bakhtiyar Khalji conquered Bengal in 1204 A.D. and established Muslim rule with *Lakhnawati* as his capital. The extension of Muslim power in Bengal may be regarded as a consequence of the establishment of the Muslim domination in northern India by Muhammad Ghorī. The Arabs, however, had established commercial contact with Bengal, particularly, with coastal areas long before the territorial conquest by the Muslim rulers. In fact there are three distinct stages in the expansion of Muslim political power in the Indian subcontinent. First, during the eighth and ninth centuries the Arabs became the foremost maritime people in the world. Their external trade as well as the Arab conquest of *Sind* and *Multan* (now within Pakistan) in 712 A.D. and their settlement in the region not only expanded Arab trade in the area but also brought the Muslims of Arabia into direct contact with the Indus valley. It opened the gates for the gradual expansion of the religion of Islam and subsequent establishment of Muslim political power in the subcontinent. Secondly, Sultan Mahmud of Ghazni invaded as far as *Kanauj* in the east and *Somnath* in *Gujarat* in the course of his seventeen expeditions; but he was not very keen on consolidating his position in the areas he invaded except a small portion in the north-west of India. In the final phase, Muhammad Ghorī established the sultanate in Delhi and laid the basis of the expansion of Muslim rule through the subcontinent. Following Ghorī's establishment of the Muslim sultanate in Delhi Bakhtiyar Khalji led an expedition to Bengal from his base in south Bihar.

Ikhtiyaruddin Muhammad Bakhtiyar Khalji was a Turkish adventurer and came to Delhi in search of a job in the army. While his effort to obtain employment at Delhi failed, he came to *Baduan* and from there he moved to

*Oudh*. The ruler of Oudh Husamuddin offered him jaigir of two Parganas (*Bhagwat* and *Vhuili*) in the south-west of *Mirzapur*. He created a sizable army with the money obtained from his jaigirs and established his power-base there. He then invaded the neighbouring Hindu Kingdoms and further strengthened his position. At one stage, he occupied *Odantapuri Vihar*, a Buddhist monastery. The Muslims called it Bihar or *Biharsharif* and the Indian state of Bihar still bears this name.

From Bihar Bakhtiyar marched towards Bengal with his army. He avoided the traditional *Teliagharh* pass (in Rajmahal) to enter Bengal and advanced through *Jharkhand*, the forest belt. Only eighteen of his horsemen could keep pace with him, when he reached Nadia where Laksman Sen, the last of the Sena Kings of Bengal was staying while the main army was following him. Bakhtiyar and his eighteen horsemen were taken as horse dealers from upper India and as such were not stopped by the city guards at any points. He went straight to the gate of the King's palace and suddenly attacked the palace security forces and killed them. At that time the old King was having his mid-day meal. When Laksman Sen heard this news he thought that the city had already been overpowered by the invaders. He hurriedly left the palace through the back door, took a boat and arrived at his capital *Vikrampur* in East Bengal. Bakhtiyar's main army soon joined him and captured the city.

The Muslim army kept the city of *Nadia* under seige for a couple of days. Bakhtiyar then moved towards *Lakhnawati* (Gaur) and established his capital there. He further advanced eastward and extended his principality to *Varendra* area in North Bengal. The whole tract of land comprising the greater portion of Northern and Western Bengal seems to have been brought under Muslim dominion. Bakhtiyar's territory, therefore, besides his original *Jaigirs* in the Mirzapur district, southern Bihar and the portion North of the Ganges, included in Bengal proper the districts of *Rajmahal* (now in Bihar), *Maldah*, *Dinajpur*, *Rajshahi*, *Rangpur* and *Bogura* in the North. The river system formed by the *Tista-Brahmaputra-Korotoa* set the eastern limit of the *Lakhnawati* principality. He soon consolidated his new conquests and established military outposts in the border areas. In his administrative arrangements he assigned different areas of his territory to the charge of his principal nobles and military chiefs for maintenance of law and order and collection of revenues. It was also their duty to look after the well-being of the people under their charge. In his effort to establish a Muslim society Bakhtiyar constructed Mosques, *Madrasas* (Muslim religious schools) and *khanqas* (shelter for the *sufis* and saints). This practice was also followed by his subordinate officers.

The last important event in Bakhtiyar's career was his expedition to Tibet. It is difficult to ascertain his motive behind this hazardous expedition through unconventional route while the largest portion of East Bengal remained outside his domain. Whatever might have been his motives it seems that he took adequate

preparation for Tibet expedition and marched at the head of a large army of ten thousand strong cavalry through the strongholds of various tribes at the foot of the Himalayas. This expedition met with disaster as most of his soldiers were lost in the journey facing a hostile army on the way. The main body of his army was drowned on its return journey while attempting to cross the river *Baranadi* near *Gauhati* in North Assam. Bakhtiyar somehow managed to cross the river with about one hundred of his soldiers. The fiasco of the Tibet expedition shattered him both mentally and physically and he died of a consuming fever or was killed by his ambitious general Ali Mardan Khalji within three months of his return to *Devkot* (Dinajpur) in 1206 A.D.

It is difficult to state Bakhtiyar's relations with the sultans of Delhi. It is not also definitely known in whose name he struck coins or addressed Friday sermon nor the nature of his allegiance to Delhi but there is hardly any doubt that he conquered Bengal on his own and conducted administration in the occupied territory freely and independently.

Bakhtiyar's conquest of Bengal proved momentous as he founded a Muslim dominion in eastern India at a time when unrest and political turmoil in central Asia and the dynastic changes at Delhi led to the immigration of Muslim chieftains, nobles, *ulemas* (persons learned in religious matters) and other people in the deltaic Bengal. With the arrival of the new rulers, new people, and a new faith, the stage was set for the subsequent changes in the society and the body politic of the country as a whole. More significant was the foundation of the Bengal Sultanate which lasted for more than three centuries and the independent sultans contributed enormously to the growth of an enlightened and prosperous Bengal during the mediaeval period.

### Bengal Sultanate

Muhammad Bakhtiyar's death in 1206 A.D. was marked by a period of confusion and disputed succession. His companions competed with one another for power at *Lakhnawti*. This internal dispute gave an opportunity to the rulers of Delhi to exert their influence in Bengal. The rivalry between the two close associates of Bakhtiyar, namely Ali Mardan Khalji and Shiran Khalji continued till Shiran was killed either by a noble or by the Hindu Zamindars. Meanwhile *Devkot* became the centre of activities by the successors of Bakhtiyar Khalji, specially during Husam Uddin Iwaj Khalji (1208- 120A.D.). But Ali Mardan supported by Kutubuddin Aibak of Delhi soon returned to Bengal and without any serious opposition captured power. After Kutubuddin Aibak's death at Delhi Ali Mardan declared himself an independent sultan of Bengal and assumed the title Sultan Alauddin.

Alauddin's oppression of the Khalji nobles and his high-handed actions as an independent Sultan alienated most of his courtiers who were united under the

leadership of Husamuddin Iwaj Khalji. They killed Sultan Ali Mardan in 1212 A.D. and offered the throne of *Lakhnawti* to Husamuddin who assumed the title of Sultan Ghyasuddin Iwaj Khalji. His rule for fifteen years was important in the history of the early Sultanate as he firmly established Muslim rule in Bengal, expanded its territory and succeeded in overcoming the internal power politics. He moved his administrative headquarters from *Devkot* to *Lakhnawti* and built a naval power to strengthen his position in riverine Bengal. His public works included construction of roads and wide canals which saved the agricultural land, and dwelling houses from floods. According to Minhaj, Iwaj Khalji extended his territory to the South as far as the northern river and the rulers of *Kamrup*, *Orissa*, *Tirhut* and eastern Bengal paid tribute to him. After consolidating his position Iwaj Khalji turned to south-eastern Bengal. But the Sultan of Delhi did not allow the status of full independence to the ruler of Bengal. After overcoming his initial problems he sent his eldest son Nasiruddin Mahmud with a large army to conquer Bengal. Nasiruddin Mahmud conquered *Lakhnawti* and killed Iwaj Khalji with many of his courtiers. But fortunately before his death Iwaj Khalji put the Muslim sultanate of Bengal on a strong footing. After the defeat of Sultan Ghyasuddin Iwaj Khalji the Muslim Kingdom of Bengal became a province of the Delhi Sultanate. The long distance from Delhi and the weakness of the central government encouraged the rulers of *Lakhnawti* to declare independence or to rule free from Delhi's intervention. For the rebellious actions of the local rulers, Ziauddin Barani, author of *Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi* mentioned that Delhi regarded Bengal as *Balgakpur* or the city of mutineers or defiant. This state of affairs continued for nearly half a century until Ghyasuddin Balban of Delhi succeeded in conquering the rebellious governor of Bengal in 1281. He appointed his son Bogra Khan as the ruler of Bengal and established the rule of the Balbans in the province.

Among the fifteen governors who had ruled Bengal from 1227 to 1281, at least ten belonged to the slaves who rose to high position by their merit. As they were Turks, their period has been called as the Turkish period of the Bengal Sultanate. Balban's invasion and conquest of *Lakhnawti* for a time put an end to the internal conflicts and paved the way for the extension of the Muslim Kingdom hitherto limited to north and north-west Bengal to south-west and south-east Bengal.

It has been stated that Ghyasuddin Balban left the administration of *Lakhnawti* to his son Bogra Khan who ruled from 1281 to 1291. He was assisted by two advisors nominated by his father. After his father's death in 1287, Bogra Khan rejected the offer of the Delhi Sultanate and became virtually independent in Bengal. At one point, he handed over the administration to his son Rokunuddin Kaikaus and retired from public life. Rokunuddin Kaikaus ruled for nine years from 1291 to 1300 A.D. He had hardly any contact with Delhi as the Delhi administration passed to the Khaljis. The coins issued by

Rokunuddin and the royal title *Sikandar-us-Sani* assumed by him were perhaps the indication of his independence from Delhi. He was succeeded by Shamsuddin Firoz Shah who ruled for about two decades as the Sultan of Bengal. From the testimony of coins and inscriptions it is known that during his time he brought *Sonargaon* (South-east Bengal) and *Satgaon* (South-west Bengal), *Mymensingh* and *Sylhet* areas under his rule. During his time the famous sufist, Shah Jalal and the sultan's general Nasiruddin conquered *Sylhet*. Shah Jalal and his more than three hundred disciples settled in *Sylhet* and preached Islam in the rural areas.

After the death of Sultan Shamsuddin Firoz his son Ghyasuddin Bahadur captured the throne of *Lakhnawti*. His unilateral action caused discontent among his brothers, particularly the youngest Nasiruddin Ibrahim who sought help from Ghyasuddin Tughlaq of Delhi, who found an opportunity to invade *Lakhnawti*. He defeated Ghyasuddin Bahadur and established his authority in Bengal. Ghyasuddin Tughlaq divided Bengal into three administrative regions - north and north-west Bengal administered from *Lakhnawti*, south-west division from *Satgaon* and east and south-east from *Sonargaon* and placed them under his nominees. Ghyasuddin Tughlaq died on his way back to Delhi and his successor Muhammad -bin -Tughlaq changed the three rulers of Bengal. At this the governor of *Sonargaon* revolted against Delhi. In 1338 on Bahram Khan's death at Sonargaon his armour bearer and close associate Fakhruddin captured power and proclaimed independence under the title of Sultan Fakhruddin Mobarak Shah. This was the beginning of the independent Sultanate in Bengal. After initial set-backs Fakhruddin continued his rule in Sonargaon and extended his territory up to Chittagong in the east. The independence declared in 1338 A.D. was retained for the subsequent two centuries. During Fakhruddin's reign the famous traveller Ibn Batuta of Morocco visited Bengal. He left an eyewitness account of Bengal and listed the prices of various items of daily necessity.

In 1342 A.D., Haji Ilias killed Alauddin Ali Shah the ruler of *Lakhnawti* assumed the title of Sultan Shamsuddin Ilias Shah. For the first time he united (by 1332 A.D) the three regions of Bengal under his independent sultanate. He was able to win over the local people to his side, gave a distinct character to his administration and earned the well deserved title of *Shahi Bangalah*. Encouraged by his initial successes Ilias Shah also sent expeditions to *Tirhut*, Nepal, Orissa and Bihar. In Bihar he occupied *Kashi* and *Gorakhpur* from the Sultan of Delhi. At this Firoz Shah Tughluq became annoyed and to curb Ilias Shah's power invaded Bengal. After several encounters both parties agreed to conclude a peace treaty. Ilias Shah also subdued *Tripura* and part of *Kamrup*. Ilias Shah's ability and courage were proved by his overwhelming authority over Bengal and his influence in the neighbouring territories. He displayed foresight in maintaining friendly relation with the rulers of Delhi and thus strengthened the foundation of the independent Sultanate of Bengal. He maintained peace all over his

territory. He was a pious ruler and highly respected the sufis and saints. He built a beautiful mosque in honour of Alaul Haq, the famous saint of his time.

After Ilyas Shah's death, his son Sikandar Shah succeeded him. During his time, Firoz Shah Tughlaq invaded Bengal for the second time. In the encounters with Sikandar Shah, no decisive result was achieved. At last, both the parties agreed to establish peace and exchanged valuable gifts. Shikandar Shah was recognized as an independent ruler. He was a great patron of architecture. The *Adina Masjid* of *Pandua* built in the latter half of the fourteenth century bears testimony to this. He also seems to have given leadership in matters of religion. This is also evident from the use of the title of Imam-ul-Azam (the chief leader) by him. During his long thirty-three years rule he maintained the unity of his territory and firmly ruled the whole country. His son Ghyasuddin Azam Shah succeeded him. After overcoming his initial problems, he devoted himself to the material and cultural development of his kingdom. Ghyasuddin Azam Shah's patronage of poets and the learned, his devotion to the sufi-saints and Islamic culture and his foreign relations earned for him a distinct place in the history of medieval Bengal. His correspondence with the famous Iranian poet Hafiz, establishment of *madrasa* at Mecca and a rest house at Madina, exchange of gifts and ambassadors between China and Bengal are very well-known. During his reign a Hindu Zamindar Raja Ganesh became powerful and in the end he captured power in 1415 probably by successive conspiratorial killings of Azam Shah, his son and successor Saifuddin Hamza Shah and subsequently usurper to the throne Shihab-uddin Baizid (a slave to his master Saifuddin Hamza Shah) and lastly Alauddin Feroz Shah.

Raja Ganesh and his family dominated the history of Bengal for about three decades. From the scanty information at our disposal, it is difficult to give a correct picture of Raja Ganesh though it is known that he was a landholder and a courtier during the Ilias Shahi Sultanate. Through manipulation and conspiracy, he captured the throne of Bengal. The leading Muslim saint Nur-Kutub-al-Alam invited Sultan Ibrahim Sharki of *Jaunpur* to invade Bengal. Ibrahim Sharki came and compelled Raja Ganesh to abdicate and converted his son Jadu to Islam and placed the latter on the throne of Bengal with the name Jalaluddin Muhammad. Some sources have indicated that Raja Ganesh made another attempt to regain the throne for the second time and held it for a brief period. But no concrete evidence could be found in favour of this statement. During Jalaluddin Muhammad's time several mint towns including *Firozabad*, *Sonargaon*, *Satgaon*, *Chittagong* and *Fatehabad* flourished. This shows that the major portions of Bengal were controlled by him. He transferred his capital from *Pandua* to Gaur where he and his family members were buried at the *Ekdala* mausoleum which is a unique design of Muslim architecture in Bengal. After a brief interval of quick successions, the courtiers and generals placed Nasir Khan, a descendant of Ilias Shah on the throne. Thus, the Ilias Shahi dynasty

was revived. Nasir Khan assumed the title of Nasiruddin Mahmud. He and his descendants ruled for about forty-five years. The latter Ilias Shahi rulers established peace throughout the country. This is evident from a number of building activities during this period including mosques, *khanqas*, gates, palaces and tombs.

Ilias Shahi rulers made distinct contributions to the history of the Bengal sultanate. They firmly established Muslim rule in Bengal and their independent status forced them to pursue an enlightened and liberal policy to gain support of the local people. Appointment of non-Muslims to high positions, veneration of vernacular languages and patronage of local scholars gave a distinct character to the Ilias Shahi rule. Apart from the development of art and architecture, promotion of religion and Muslim culture led to the expansion of Islam in rural areas of Bengal. Bengal was also linked with Muslim countries as well as with far eastern China. It seems that the Muslim military victory in Bengal combined with cultural liberalism gave rise, for the first time, to a new kind of society that ultimately shaped the real identity of Bengal.

During the reign of Barbak Shah and his son Yasuf Shah, the Habshis (slaves brought mostly from Abyssinia) became prominent by virtue of their number and position they held over the past years. Taking advantage of the weakness of the last Ilias Shahi ruler Jalaluddin Fateh Shah, his palace guard Sultan Shahjada killed him and captured the throne in 1486 under the title Barbak Shah. Thus ended the Ilias Shahi rule and in its place the Habshi rule began in Bengal. The Habshi rule lasted for six years from 1487 to 1493. Their rule constituted one of the darkest period of Bengal as it was marked by conspiracies, rebellions, murder and usurpation of power.

The last of the Habshi rulers Shamsuddin Muzaffar Shah became unpopular for his cruelty and oppression. Anarchy reigned supreme everywhere in Bengal. Amidst these unsettled conditions, the nobles and courtiers revolted and killed him. With his death the Habshi rule came to an end.

A powerful courtier Syed Husain established himself as the sultan with the title Alauddin Husain Shah. On his assumption to power the Husain Shahi period in Bengal history began and four sultans of this dynasty ruled Bengal from 1493 to 1538. It is known that Husain Shah's family originated from Arabia and settled in *Murshidabad* (West Bengal). He worked under Muzaffar Shah at Gaur and gradually rose to the position of a minister. At the very out-set, he suppressed the rebellious elements in the army and created a new security force in place of the *paiks* who participated in the killing of earlier sultans. The Habshis were driven out of the country. He appointed the Muslim noble-men coming from Turkey, Arabia and Afghanistan and the local Hindus to high government posts.

Husain Shah also extended his territory in the north and south Bihar and to *Kamta-Kamrup*. From *Kamrup* he seems to have sent an expedition to Assam

and occupied the plain land for sometime in the dry season. It is also known that he conquered part of *Assam*, *Tripura* and *Chittagaon* in the early years of the sixteenth century. Husain Shah's military successes were remarkable. For his administrative ability and successes he was known as *Nripati Tilak* (Jewel of Kings). He died after twenty-six years of his rule. His son Nusat Shah ascended the throne after him. One of the significant aspects of his reign was his relation with the rulers of Delhi. In 1526, Mughal rule was established in Delhi. Nusrat Shah maintained good relations with the founder of the Mughal Empire emperor Babar who suspected his association with the retreating Afghan leaders. In the face of Afghan resistance in the east Babar was forced to advance as far as Gogra river but he abstained from attacking Bengal. Thus Nusrat Shah's territory was saved from the Mughal hands. After his death in 1532 his son Firoz occupied the throne with the help of a section of *amirs*; but soon he was killed by his uncle Mahmud Shah. During Mahmud Shah's rule the Afghans regained their strength under the leadership of Sher Khan Sur and captured power in Bengal in 1538. This put an end to the two centuries of independent sultanate in Bengal.

Alauddin Husain Shah and his successors ruled Bengal for four and half decades. This period formed the most glorious chapter in the history of medieval Bengal. Allegiance of all sections of the Bengal population and the happy combination of local and foreign talents gave a distinct force to the Husain Shahi dynasty.

Alauddin Husain Shah was the greatest sultan of his dynasty. He brought internal peace and stability by suppressing the Habshis. He expanded his territory by conquering neighbouring kingdoms. He was an efficient ruler. He introduced a welfare administration and led Bengal to prosperity. He treated all his subjects equally, irrespective of religious faiths and appointed local Hindus to high positions including those of his ministers, personal physicians, mint masters and advisers.

Husain Shah was a great patron of learning. Under his liberal patronage many books were written in the Bengali Language. *Mahabharata* and *Bagabata Gita* were also translated into Bengali. Various literary works of his period earned distinct fame for the country. He erected many buildings including mosques, *madrasas*, *khanqas* and tombs. *Choto Sona Masjid* of Gaur and other buildings constructed during his period bear testimony to his love of architecture. He created a mosque in *Pandua* in honour of Sufi Nur Kutub-Alam and contributed land and money for his *darga*. His tolerance for other religions earned him the respect of *Sri Chaitannya Dev*, the founder of *Vaishnavism*. Worship of '*Sattya Pir*' in his time is another example of his liberal views. He wanted to bring the Hindus and the Muslims closer. Thus the glories of Husain Shahi Bengal included territorial expansion, administrative stability and development of economy, literature, religion and architecture. The rulers needed local support and allegiance against foreign invasion. To create a popular base

they appointed local people to high administrative positions. The political stability thus created led to the success of the rulers in all fields. The military success resulted in the inclusion within Bengal of the countries up to the confluence of the Ganges in the West, *Chittagong* in the east and *Kamrup* (Assam) in the north. It was this period which witnessed the beginning of significant forces deeply affecting the political and economic history of Bengal. Between the first advent of the Europeans and end of Mughal rule, this period saw the historical processes, which shaped the life of the country for centuries to come. "Mughal rule touched only the outer fringe of Bengal politics and the European trade was yet to have a proper beginning. But the period in question showed the signs of a new Bengal to be brought into existence through the working of those forces". (M.R. Tafdar :*Hussain Shahi Bengal, 1494-1538 A.D.*, Dhaka-1965, P-351).

Within less than a century of the foundation of Muslim rule the principality of *Lakshnawati* expanded to include the regions on either side of the *Bhagirathi* river. But as a result of the disintegration of the *Tughlaq* rule, independent kingdoms came into being in different parts of the subcontinent including Bengal. The first phase of independence in Bengal was represented by the *Ilyas Shahi* rule. The rulers who had to depend upon regional patriotism in the process of countering the authority of Delhi adopted a secular policy in the administration. In the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries, it is noticed that a considerable number of non-Muslims held high posts under Muslim rulers and formed the landed aristocracy of the country. Thus the sultans made significant contributions to the growth of a Hindu middle class "with all its economic and cultural paraphernalia".

With the foundation of the independent sultanate ports like *Satgaon*, *Sonargaon* and *Chittagong* came into prominence. These together with a number of mint towns greatly encouraged Bengal's maritime trade with the outside world. Thus the Muslim rule brought Bengal "from rural to urban phase of civilisation based on the introduction of money economy". (M. R. Tafdar: *Hussain Shahi Bengal, 1497-1538 A.D.*, P. 30).

### Society and Culture

Bakhtyar Khalji's conquest of Bengal and establishment of the Muslim Kingdom led to the growth of a Muslim Society in this country. Before Muslim rule population of Bengal was composed mainly of the Hindus, the Buddhists, aboriginals, and a few Jains. Subsequently new elements like parsees, the Portuguese and the Armenians were added to the existing population. The aboriginals though constituting a sizeable population were not considered as belonging to the mainstream of the society. The Jain population gradually declined. (Jainism accepted the Brahmanical doctrine of '*karma*' and '*rebirth*' but rejected the authority of the vedas, the caste system and the practice of animal

sacrifice. They by and large considered themselves as Hindus, differing from them only in certain philosophical and theological aspects). With the fall of the Buddhist Pala rule and the ascendancy of the Senas with aggressive *Brahmanical* domination Buddhism fast declined and eventually it is said that it disappeared from the land of its birth. It still counts one third of population of the world as its followers. The Hindus outnumbered the other religious communities and were also politically and economically advanced. The caste system dominated their social life including their manners, morals and thoughts. The four hereditary occupational groups namely, the **Brahmans** (the priestly class), **Khatriyas** (the political and military groups), the **Vaishas** (in charge of trade, agriculture and commerce) and **Sudras** (service groups) had existed for a long time. Each class was separated from the other by its obligatory rules and social contacts in any form were prohibited. The oppression of the lower castes by the Brahmins had a demoralising effect on the existing society.

Under these circumstances after the conquest of Bengal by Bakhtiyar Khalji in the early thirteenth century the Muslim population began to grow. It was composed of local converts as well as the Muslims who came from outside and settled in Bengal. The Muslim rulers, their relatives, officials and the thousands of soldiers who came in the wake of Muslim invasion ultimately settled in this land. Soon many other immigrants from Turkey, Iran, Abyssinia, Central Asia, Arabia, Afghanistan and upper India joined them. They all formed the immigrant Muslims along with the hundreds of *sufis* who arrived in Bengal with their followers.

The Muslim rulers played a significant part in building the Muslim society in Bengal. The aim of the Sultans was not only to continue Muslim rule but also build institutions and initiate works that helped Muslim society and culture. One of their first acts was the creation of Mosques. Mosques formed the most important feature of Muslim society and culture as the places of prayer— one of the fundamental pillars of Muslim faith. They were built in such locations as were convenient for the people to perform their religious duties. *Adina Mosque* of Pandua, *Khan Jahan Mosque* at Bagerhat, *Jafar Khan Mosque* at Tribeni are examples. The sultans also established *Maktabas* and *Madrasas* for imparting religious education. *Madrasas* were also established by private initiations with or without government assistance. Many of them maintained residential accommodation providing food and lodgings for both teachers and students. The sultans also offered facilities to pilgrims to visit Makka and Madina during Haj. Some of the sultans and their officers were famous for their learning and proficiency in the Quran, Hadith (tradition of the prophet) and the Islamic law. They in turn encouraged similar education for their subjects. The benevolent activities of the sultans in the form of constructions of wells, excavation of tank and grant of lands to maintain *almshouses* were aimed at easing the distress of the common people.

The learned people *Ulama* occupied a high position in the Muslim society. They imparted religious education in many ways including lessons on Islamic sciences namely, *Fiqh* and *Hadith* and upheld the Muslim religious tradition by their activities. They were paid in a number of ways for their works through stipends, land grants or facilities to visit the holy places.

A large number of *sufis* came to Bengal. According to local tradition some of them had come even before the Muslim conquest. There is hardly any town or locality where a sufi had not come and settled. Their contributions in the preaching and expansion of Islam in rural Bengal were very great. They helped in the following ways; First, they extended help to expand Muslim political power when needed, Secondly, their influence over the ruling classes was an additional attraction to the people, Thirdly, they gave religious instructions to everybody who gathered round their *Khanqas*; Finally, their influence over society as spiritual leaders and comforters of people in distress spread among the masses who were gradually attracted to the new faith.

The sultans, the Muslim scholars and the sufi-saints who came and settled contributed enormously to the formation and growth of the Muslim society and culture in medieval Bengal. The main tenets of Islam - its unqualified faith in one universal God, the brotherhood of Muslims and equal status of men, accountability and duties to God as well as to creation attracted many local people who became suspicious of their own religion or were oppressed under the strict regulations and practices of the caste system.

The spread of Islam and the formation of the Muslim society under the Bengal sultanate did not however go unchallenged. There were reactions which took different forms: first, people accepted the new faith as they thought it would be their conversion to faith with a manifest ideology of equity; secondly, the orthodox section adhered to their own faith, right or wrong; lastly, the establishment of Islam created an urge among a section of enlightened people to reform their own religion taking good things of Islam and shunning bad things from their own religion.) The best example in the early sixteenth century is the preaching of *Vaishnavism* by Chaitanya Dev who ignored the caste rules and advocated equality of all worshippers and emphasized the importance of *Bhakti* or ardent love and devotion to one God.

Action and reaction between Islam and local Hinduism continued all through the Muslim rule in Bengal, caused on occasion by liberal patronage of some Muslim rulers. Alauddin Husain Shahi's liberal policy encouraged the social and religious reform movements as the one pioneered by *Sri Chaitanya*. Years of association with non-Muslims who far out-numbered them, and living with 'half converts' from Hinduism Muslims also deviated from their original faith and became Bengalised by bringing Islamic elements near local practices as well as by accepting some local elements directly. The preparation of *Tazia* to observe Moharram festival in the way of *Durga* sacrifice and *Rathjatra*, worship of

*Panchpir*, *Satya pir*, *Saint Worship* and *Tirtha* or visits to the shrines of sufis are some of the examples of liberalization of the society. The Caste system was also unconsciously imitated by the Muslims and this created a sense of aristocracy among the upper class Muslims ignoring the Islamic idea of brotherhood and equality.

The sultans of Bengal attached great importance to education as it was considered part of their religious duties. As a result there was a remarkable progress of learning and knowledge in medieval Bengal in which the Muslim and the Hindu scholars greatly contributed. Translation of Sanskrit works into Bengali added significance to literary life. *Lakhnawati*, *Sonargaon*, *Nagor*, *Mandaram*, *Rangpur* and *Chittagong* became centres of Islamic learning whereas *Navadhip*, *Sylhet*, and *Vishnupore* were developed as the centres of Sanskrit and Hindu religious studies. Development of Bengali language and literature was more significant during the sultanate period. It helped the integration of the Bengali speaking territory and population. Bangla language was given a respectable place at the court as well as in the civil society. Sultan Ghyasuddin Azam Shah and Alauddin Husain liberally patronized the Bengali poets and literature in his effort to promote Bangla language. A large body of literature grew up round the life and teachings of Chaitanya. This brought forth a new social and cultural understanding between the Hindus and the Muslims in building a common platform of the two communities of Bengal.

The Bengali society under the sultanate was by and large divided into a number of classes. The ruling class was at the top and the slaves lay at the bottom. Between these two classes there were the aristocrats consisting of high officials, big landlords and members of the nobility. The landed gentry generally known as the Zamindar formed the common landed aristocracy. There was also a sizeable middle class which included teachers, clerks, traders, officers, and other professional groups earning a living by their physical and intellectual work. Below them there was the large group of commoners consisting of cultivators, small manufactures, shopkeeper, agricultural and industrial labour and other lower class employees. Slaves were drawn from several sources: first, prisoners of war were generally converted into slaves; secondly, there are also evidences of the sale of children by poor parents or guardians from extreme pecuniary distress. Besides the above, a large number of slaves were imported from foreign countries such as Abyssinia, Central and West Asia, Armenia and Georgia. The Hindu social structure was mostly caste ridden, though the policy pursued by the independent sultans had some liberalising effect on Hindu Society. Educated Hindus other than the Bramhans could also be appointed to the higher administrative positions and by their influence could cross the caste barrier. In the Muslim social structure the sultans and their family formed the upper class; the *Sheikhs*, *Syeds*, *Mughals* and the *Pathans* formed the traditional aristocrat groups. The *Ulama*, *Mashaekh*, and the Professional groups like Mufti, *Muhtasib*

and other officials belonged to the enlightened group and below them there were the common people, servants and slaves. According to Islamic principles Muslim society cannot be structured like this. Yet it seems that there was the influence of the Hindu caste system prevailing all over the country.

During the Bengal sultanate Muslim society expanded and this period was the formative phase of the political and socio-cultural life of Bengal. The real identity of Bengal and Bengali people began with the establishment of the independent sultanate in Bengal. It also contributed to the growth of distinctive characteristic and institutions of the Bengali people. The interaction of Islam and Hinduism in practical life led to 'syncretistic tradition' in the Bengal society. Bengali Language brought about a unique sense of unity among the people. There was also economic prosperity due to internal stability and extension of external trade based on indigenous manufacture and agricultural products. The unity that was achieved under the independent sultanate provided the basis for the strength of the people of Bengal. The Bengal sultanate, therefore, formed the most constructive period of the history of Bengal. Independence and unity of Bengal together with the strong civil and military administration with popular support, economic and educational development, overwhelming influence of Bengali language, international relations, and secular policy based on religious tolerance thus left a precious legacy for posterity.

## Reference

- M.A. Rahim - *Social and Cultural History of Bengal*, Vol.1 (1201-1576), Karachi 1963.  
 A.Karim - *Social History of the Muslims of Bengal*, (Down to A. D. 1538) Dhaka-1959.  
 M.E. Haq - *A History of Sufism in Bengal*, Dhaka 1975.  
 Asim Roy - *The Islamic Syncretistic Tradition in Bengal*, Princeton, 1983.  
 M.R. Tarafdar - *Husain Shahi Bengal, 1494 - 1558*, A Socio-Political Study, Dhaka 1965.  
 Richard. M. Eaton - *The Rise of Islam and the Bengal Frontier, 1204 - 1760*, Delhi 1994.  
 J.N. Sarkar - *History of Bengal*, Vol. II, Dhaka 1972.  
 M.Mohar Ali - *History of the Muslims of Bengal*, Vols. I A & I B, Riyadh, -1983.  
 R.C. Majumdar - *History of Bengal* (Mediaeval period).  
 M.A.Rahim and others - *Bangladesher Itihas*, (in Bengali) Dhaka, 1981.

## CHAPTER FOUR

### Bengal Under the Mughals: Politics, Society and Culture

Abdul Karim

**T**he Muslim rule in Bengal continued for about five centuries and a half, from Bakhtyar Khalji's conquest in 1204-05 to the Battle of Plassey in 1757. After the battle, the English East India Company became the controlling power in Bengal's politics; the administration, however, was carried on in the name of the puppet Nawabs for some years more. The period of Muslim rule is divided into two phases – Sultanate and Mughal, the Sultanate rule ending in 1576, when in the battle of Rajmahal on 12<sup>th</sup> July, the last Afghan Sultan Daud Khan Karrani was defeated by Khan Jahan, the general of the great Mughal emperor Akbar. Daud Karrani was beheaded and the capital Tanda was occupied. It meant the end of the Sultan and the Sultanate, but the Mughal conquest of Bengal was far off. The Mughal army controlled and established authority over a small portion surrounding the capital city; they kept open and safe their supply and base line to Delhi, but the rest of Bengal was controlled by independent and semi-independent military Chiefs, the Afghans, and Bengali Bhuiyans and Rajas, both Muslims and Hindus. Akbar made strenuous efforts by sending general after general, to bring the whole of Bengal under his control but failed. His dream of conquering Bengal was fulfilled in the reign of his son Jahangir by a young, energetic Subahdar, Islam Khan Chishti.

Besides the chiefs and the Bhuiyans, Bengal's climate and geography also offered great resistance to the Mughal aggression in Bengal. Bengal is a country where the monsoon prevails for almost half of the year. There are many rivers and water-channels, deep and shallow. In fact one comes across a river every 25 kilometres or so. The riverine scene of Bengal is dominated by big rivers, the

Ganges and the Brahmaputra, the former coming out of the Himalayas runs through upper India into Bengal, the latter also comes out of the Himalayan ranges and coming east enters Bengal through Assam and Kamrup. The Ganges again bifurcates into two on entering Bengal, one going to the east takes the name Padma and meets with other rivers and channels before falling into the sea; the other going to the south takes the name Bhagirathi and joining with other rivers and channels falls into the sea passing through Hugli and Calcutta. The Brahmaputra was also a mighty river (now-a-days losing its former glory) and following southwards going with a labyrinth of channels including the mighty Padma and taking the name of Meghna flows down to the sea. Then in north Bengal there are Mahananda, Tista, Karatoya and Atreyi and in south Bengal the Bhairab, the Madumati and Ariyal Khan, all distributors of the Ganges. Surma, Gomati and the two Feni rivers are important waterways in eastern Bengal, the last two forming the borderline between Bengal and the Kingdom of Arakan in the Mughal period.

The natural geography of Bengal as stated above offered barriers to the Mughal conquest of Bengal, but the political geography offered no small barrier. Bengal was occupied by a large number of independent, semi-independent Bhuiyans, Rajas, and Afghan chiefs on the eve of the Mughal conquest. Taking advantage of change of government at the centre and the resultant instability during the twilight of the Afghan Sultanate, they established authority in different parts of Bengal. There were, for example, Bir Hammir of Bishnupur (Bankura-Birbhum), Shams Khan of Pachet and Salim Khan of Hijli (Medinipur area); there were Pitambar, Ananta of Chilajawar and Illah Bakhsh of Alaipur, all in north Bengal centring on Rajshahi; there were Raja Pratapaditya of Jessore, Raja Mukunda and his son Raja Satrajit of Bhushna (eastern part of Jessore); Raja Kandarpa Narayan and his son Raja Ram Chandra of Bakla (Bakerganj). There were Raja Lakshman Manikya and Ananta Manikya of Bhulna (Noakhali), Khawaja Usman Afghan and his brothers at Bukainagar (Gauripur, greater Mymensingh) and Bayazid Karrani of Sylhet; Usman and Bayazid were Afghan chiefs. Then there were the Bhuiyans of Bhati, their chief in Akbar's time was Isa Khan Masnad-i-Ala and in Jahangir's time Isa Khan's son Musa Khan Masnad-i-Ala. Of the other prominent Bhuiyans of Bhati, mention may be made of Chand Rai and his brother Kedar Rai of Bikrampur, and the Ghazis of Bhowal. Khwaja Usman and the Bara Bhuiyans proved to be the most serious obstacle to Mughal aggression in Bengal.

Khwaja Usmans were four brothers, they were sons of Isa Khan (not to be confused with Isa Khan Masnad-i-Ala of Bhati) minister of Qatlu Khan of Orissa. Usman along with his brothers and other Afghans put up stubborn resistance to the Mughals in Orissa, but being defeated were banished by the Mughals to Bengal. Solaiman was the eldest of all, and upon his death in Bengal, the leadership devolved upon the second brother Usman. Coming to Bengal, they

travelled through Satgaon and Bhushna and ultimately established authority at Bokainagar. Raja Protapaditya was the son of Sri Hari. On the occasion of Daud Karrani's fall, his ministers, both Sri Hari and his colleague Qatlu Khan sided with the Mughals and thus Sri Hari got the Zamindari of a big estate at Jessore. The Rajas of Bhushna, Bakla and Bhulua were all hereditary chiefs. They offered nominal submission to the authority at the capital and thus enjoyed undisturbed succession. But the great enemies of the Mughals were the Bara Bhuiyans, who resisted the Mughal advance to Bengal for several decades. The chief of the Bara Bhuiyans was Isa Khan in the time of Akbar and Musa Khan in the time of Jahangir. Both assumed the leadership of the Bhuiyans and took the title of Masnad-i-Ala. Isa Khan was the son of Kalidas Gajdani, a Bias Rajput, said to be a Diwan of Sultan Ghias-ud-din Mahmud Shah of Bengal (1533-38). He married the daughter of the Sultan, accepted Islam and took the name of Sulaiman Khan. During the Reign of Islam Shah Sur (Salim Shah) son of Sher Shah, Sulaiman Khan rebelled and was killed. Isa and his brother Ismail were sent to exile in Iran, but later on being allowed to return, Isa Khan took upon the management of his father's estate. He owed allegiance to the Karrani Sultans, and after the fall of the Karranis, joined with other Bhuiyans and taking leadership fought against the Mughals till his death in 1599 A.D. Masum Khan Kabuli, a Mughal military officer also joined with Isa Khan. In 1580 the Mughal captains in Bengal revolted, and set up a rebel government. Akbar suppressed the rebellion and re-established his authority, but though others submitted, Musum Khan Kabuli chose to remain a rebel. He assumed independence, but died in 1599 leaving a son, Mirza Mumin, who also joined the Bara Bhuiyans. Kedar Rai of Sripur-Bikrampur also put up a stubborn resistance to the Mughals. He fought a few hotly contested battles with Raja Mansingh, Akbar's subahdar of Bengal. Kedar Rai received mortal wounds in one such battle and died in 1602. Although the leaders were dead their successors took up the field and continued their struggle in the reign of Jahangir, when finally the Bara Bhuiyans were made to submit by Islam Khan Chishti, Jahangir's subahdar of Bengal.

Jahangir's first few years remained static in the Mughal advance to Bengal, but with the appointment of Islam Khan Chishti as subahdar in 1608 the situation was completely changed. The new subahdar claimed noble birth; he was the grandson of Shaikh Salim Chishti, a sufi saint of Fatehpur Sikri. The relation between the family of the emperor and Shaikh was most cordial. Although the subahdar was an inexperienced young fellow, the emperor's choice could not have been better. Joining his office in the then capital Rajmahal, Islam Khan Chishti drew up an accomplished plan of operation. He decided to transfer the capital from Rajmahal, situated at the western end of the subah, to a suitable eastern strategic place. He found that the greatest enemy of the Mughals were the Bara-Bhuiyans and the Afghans under Khwaja Usman; their strength lay in Eastern Bengal. So Islam Khan decided to transfer the capital to the heart of

Bhati, and ultimately chose Dhaka as capital. He also perceived that Bengal was a riverine country where Mughal cavalry was ineffective for almost half of the year. So he strengthened the Mughal navy and at his request the emperor posted Ihtimam Khan to place the navy on a sound footing. The Bara Bhuiyans were strong in river warfare, so the Mughal navy was organized in such a way to be able to annihilate the local flotilla of war boats. The Subahdar started with his numerous boats and artillery from Rajmahal towards Bhati.

On the way he subjugated the zamindars and chiefs on both sides of the Ganges. On reaching the heart of Bhati he made Dhaka, the capital and from there he subjugated the Bara Bhuiyans in about two years and defeated one by one the Rajas of Jessore, Bakla and Bhulua and also defeated Khwaja Usman Afghan and his brothers and Bayazid Karrani of Sylhet. By the end of 1612 the whole of Bengal except Chittagong was brought under Mughal control. The next year he also occupied the neighbouring kingdom of Kamrup. Formerly, if the Mughal General occupied an area, and the Rajas and Zamindars/Bhuiyans who surrendered were reinstated in their position on promise of remaining loyal and paying tribute. But as soon as the Mughal army retraced their steps, the subjugated Bhuiyans, Chiefs, Rajas shook off allegiance, gathered fresh strength and became independent.

Islam Khan examined the situation very carefully; so he did not allow the defeated chiefs to go back to their station, but they were forced into Mughal service. They were compelled to fight against their brethren. This policy of Islam Khan became extremely effective and the power of the Rajas, Bhuiyans or zamindars and chiefs was so crippled that they could never again raise their head. So the Mughal authority in Bengal was consolidated.

Ibrahim Khan Fathejang, another Subahdar of Jahangir conquered Tippera and ousted the King from his throne, but within a couple of years Tippera regained her independence. The rebel Prince Shahjahan came to Bengal and remained there for a few months. After his flight towards the Deccan, Jahangir's authority was re-established. Shahjahan's first subahdar of Bengal, Quasim Khan did an excellent service by expelling the Portuguese from Hugli in 1632 AD. The Portuguese had established a settlement at Hugli around 1580 with the permission of the Emperor Akbar, but in the guise of trade, they indulged in unlawful activities, and Hugli under them was going to be an imperium in imperio, so their power had to be curbed. Soon afterwards the Portuguese were allowed to return, but their former power and glory was gone. During the subahdari of Prince Shah Shuja, Bengal enjoyed peace for twenty years, 1639-1658, but when the emperor Shahjahan fell ill the Mughal empire was plunged into a civil war in which all the four princes – Dara, Shuja, Aurangzeb and Murad took part. Shuja enthroned himself at Rajmahal; he fought first against Dara, then against Aurangzeb, but being defeated finally in 1660, took shelter with the king of Arakan. There he was brutally murdered in 1661 A.D.

Mir Jumla, who defeated and drove Shuja out of Bengal, was appointed Subahdar. Born of a humble origin in Iran, Mir Muhammad Said, more famous in history by his surname Mir Jumla, came to Golconda in South India in the service of an Iranian merchant. Later he made a fortune for himself. He engaged himself in the diamond business and gradually rose to be a merchant of name and fame; his diamonds were counted by the sack -full and he also owned many ships. He was also appointed wazir in the Sultanate of Golconda, but later he moved to the Mughal empire in the service of Shahjahan and then of Aurangzeb. In Bengal, Mir Jumla's chief contribution was the conquest of Assam, but he fell seriously ill in the course of the campaign. He tried to return, but died on the way. His conquered possessions in Assam also went out of hands.

The next great Mughal Subahdar in Bengal was Shaista Khan. He was in Bengal for about 22 years with a short break in the middle, when Azam Khan Koka (Fidai Khan) and Prince Muhammad Azam became Subahdars. Shaista Khan came of a noble family; his father was Asaf Khan, father of Mumtaz Mahal consort of Shahjahan. Asaf Khan was the son of Itimid-ud-dawla (Mirza Ghias Beg) and brother of Nur Jahan, queen of Jahangir. Shaista Khan came to Bengal at the age of 63 with several grown-up sons and with their help and co-operation he ruled Bengal ably and with distinction. But his great fame in Bengal lay in his conquest of Chittagong. The Magh king of Arakan with the aid of Portuguese pirates used to attack Bengal and the pirates left the coastal regions desolate, burning and looting property and enslaving men, women and children. By a careful policy Shaista Khan won over the Portuguese pirates and with their help conquered Chittagong. Arakan never again dared to invade Bengal. Shaista Khan was kind and liberal. He spent for the welfare of the poor, indigent and religious persons; built mosques, bridges and sarais. In his time the price of grain was extremely low so that rice was sold at 8 maund per rupee. He was gentle, amiable and humane so much so that he was described as a pattern of excellence.

After Shaista Khan, Khan Jahan Bahadur became Subahdar for a short tenure, Ibrahim Khan followed him. In his time, Shova Singh, a zamindar of Chandrakona in Midnapur district revolted and joining with Rahim Khan, an Afghan leader of Orissa looted and plundered an extensive territory including the port of Hugli. Subahdar Ibrahim Khan was a man of scholarly disposition; he failed to take any measure against the miscreants. So Aurangzeb recalled him and appointed in his place Muhammad Azim-ud-din (entitled Azim-ush-shan), his grandson. The rebels were punished, but in his desire to amass wealth, he allowed the English East India Company to purchase from the lawful owners, the three villages of Sutanuti, Govindapur and Kalikata. Thus the English laid the foundation of Calcutta (Kalikata), which later played a very important part in the history not only of Bengal, but also of India.

After the death of Aurangzeb in 1707, and with the resultant war of succession and the ambitions of Mughal princes and nobility, the central government of

the Mughals became very weak giving rise to provincial kingdoms. In Bengal, Murshid Quli Khan, a last great imperial officer was able to place himself at the head of every branch of administration. He sent the imperial revenue regularly and thus kept the emperor and his ministers happy. Murshid Quli Khan was the Subahdar of Bengal and Orissa and Diwan of Bihar. He also got the lofty title of Mustamin-ul-Mulk Ala-ud-dowla Jafar Khan Nasiri Nasir Jang. He became the de facto ruler of Bengal. But the emperor and the central government continued to repose confidence in him. Appointment of subordinate offices was made through his recommendation. He became the focus of attention in the provinces. Members of his family, his relatives and his favourites got preference in all branches of administration. That is why his period of administration in Bengal is known as *niabat* or the *nawabi* period. Another important measure of Murshid Quli Khan was to transfer the capital from Dhaka to Murshidabad.

Murshid Quli Khan died in 1727 leaving no male issue and he hoped that his grandson (son of his daughter) Asadullah entitled Sarfaraz Khan would succeed him and he recommended him to the emperor accordingly. His son-in-law (Sarfaraz's father) Shuja-ud-din Muhammad Khan was holding the post of deputy subahdar of Orissa. He now forestalled his son and occupied the masnad of Murshidabad. He was also appointed Subahdar of Bihar and from this time Bengal, Bihar, Orissa came under one person, both in Nizamat and Diwani administration. Shuja-ud-din appointed Alivardi Khan his deputy in Bihar. Shuja-ud-din ruled peacefully for more than a decade until his death in 1739. For better administration he divided the three provinces of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa into four divisions, and he also created a council of advisors consisting of Alivardi Khan (deputy subahdar of Bihar), Haji Ahmad (Alivardi's elder brother), Diwan Rai Rayan Alam Chand and the great banker Jagat Seth. The Hindus were already getting higher jobs from the time of Murshid Quli Khan, but now got entry in to the advisory council. But Alivardi Khan and Haji Ahmad, the two brothers proved to be great conspirators and they appointed Haji Ahmad's three grown-up sons into key positions like Faujdar, Diwan etc. When, after his father's death Sarfaraz Khan sat on the Masnad, Alivardi, in league with other members of the council conspired against him and marched from Patna at the head of an army. In the encounter that followed Sarfaraz Khan was killed and Alivardi occupied the Masnad of Murshidabad.

Alivardi Khan, entitled Mahabat Jang, was 64 when he sat on the masnad of Murshidabad in 1740. He died in 1756 at the age of 80. At this old age also he ruled vigorously. He had to suppress several rebellions including that of Rustam Jang (Mirza Lutfullah, Murshid Quli Khan II), son-in-law of Shuja-ud-din Muhammad Khan. Rustam Jang did not submit to Alivardi but fought against him and was defeated. His general Mir Habib then invited the Marathas to invade Orissa. The Maratha menace became the greatest problem for Alivardi Khan, and the repeated Maratha incursions seriously damaged the prestige of the

Nawab, who ultimately had to buy peace ceding Orissa and promising to pay twelve lac rupees annually to the Marathas. Alivardi had no male issue; his three daughters were married to his three nephews, sons of Haji Ahmad. They were given higher posts: the eldest Nawazish Muhammad was entitled Shalhamat Jang and was appointed Naib Nazim of Dhaka, the second Said Ahmad Khan was appointed in Purnea with the title of Saalat Jang and the third Zain-ud-din Ahmad was appointed to Patna with the title of Khan, and they were known by their stations, Dhaka nawab, Purnea nawab and Patna nawab. All his nephews predeceased Alivardi; and breavements, rebellions and the Maratha menace, all caused terrible depression on the mind of the Nawab. His health was seriously affected and he died in April 1756.

Alivardi Khan was survived by four grandsons, a grown-up son Shawkat Jang, and a boy Mirza Ramzani by his second daughter, two sons Siraj-ud-dowla and Mirza Mahdi by his third and youngest daughter, his eldest daughter Meherun-Nisa alias Ghasiti Begum was childless. Sirajud-dowla was Alivardi's darling, he was born in the year in which Alivardi got the deputy subahdari of Bihar, so Siraj was regarded as a bringer of good fortune. Siraj occupied the Masnad, but he soon found himself surrounded by enemies. His own aunt Ghasiti Begum, an ambitious lady, was his greatest enemy; then there was Shawkat Jang, his cousin of Purnea and he had another political enemy Mir Muhammad Jafar Ali Khan (Mir Jafar), the commander of the army. Ghasiti Begum brought-up Akram-ud-dowla, Siraj's brother from childhood, and cherished the idea of ruling the country from behind the veil through her adopted son. But Akram-ud-dowla predeceased Alivardi, so Ghasiti Begum favoured the case of Shawkat Jang. The latter was ambitious but worthless, and was defeated and killed in an encounter in the battle of Manihari against Siraj. Then there were the Hindu officers and the bankers, particularly Jagat Seth who was raised to position of influence by Alivardi Khan and his predecessors. They had nothing to lose if any of the contending parties won or lost, they knew how to manage each and every turn of events in their favour.

Siraj-ud-dowla succeeded to the masnad at the age of 23. He first paid attention to streamlining the administration and in so doing he created enemies and faced opposition from different quarters. He asked Raj Ballabh to clear the accounts of the Dhaka Niabat (deputy of the Nawab in charge of administration), because he was there the *pishkar*. When he failed to clear the accounts, he was confined, but his son Krishna Ballabh escaped to Calcutta with his family and treasures. Siraj asked the English East India Company not to give shelter to the fugitives, who were his subjects and were under trial. But the English refused to hand over the criminals to the Nawab's government. The English also committed other offences against the Nawab and began fortification of Calcutta without permission. No government could tolerate such insolence, so Siraj came out of Murshidabad and attacked Calcutta. The English were driven out, and took

shelter in ships out of Nawab's reach, but they came back with reinforcements from Madras. The Company secretly entered into a pact with the disaffected officials of the Nawab, like Mir Jafar, Raj Ballabh, Rai Durlabh and the great banker Jagat Set. According to the secret treaty the English agreed to place Mir Jafar on the masnad with their arms, and Mir Jafar agreed to grant territorial, financial and trade facilities to the English. Armed with the treaty, Robert Clive the English General marched against the Nawab and took position at the plain of Plassey. The Nawab also came out with his army, but while the Nawab's army was engaged in a hot battle, and the English were about to be defeated, Mir Jafar instead of bringing the battle to a successful conclusion, advised the Nawab to postpone the battle for the next day. Accordingly, while the Nawab ordered his army to cease hostilities for the day, Mir Jafar sent secret information to Clive to launch a vigorous attack. The Nawab's soldiers were taken aback. Many had already laid down arms for taking rest; some who turned back could not withstand the enemy attack. So the Nawab was defeated due to the treachery of Mir Jafar. He fled but was brought back captive, and later beheaded. Robert Clive took Mir Jafar by the hand and placed him on the Masnad of Murshidabad. In fact there was hardly any change, one Nawab making place for another, as happened many times before, but in practice the English became the controller of affairs, and step-by-step sovereignty passed to their hands.

### New Forces at Work

With the coming of the Mughals into Bengal, the country witnessed the working of certain new forces in the administrative, social, economic and cultural life. These forces transformed Bengal's life and thought. Unlike the previous period, when she enjoyed independence, Bengal now became a part, i.e., a province of the centralised Mughal empire under one administration, one law, one official language, uniform official cadre and uniform currency. Emperor Akbar divided the empire into several provinces called Subah. While doing so, due consideration was given to geographical feature, natural boundaries and language. Bengal became a Subah with the Bengali-speaking people enclosed by well-demarcated natural boundaries. During the Mughal conquest of Bengal, the capital was at Tanda, 15 miles south-east of Malda, now washed away by the river, but before the end of Akbar's reign, Subahdar Man Singh transferred the capital to Rajmahal renamed Akbarnagar. In the reign of Jahangir, Subahdar Islam Khan Chishti transferred the capital to Dhaka, renamed Jahangirnagar and finally in the early 18<sup>th</sup> century Murshid Quli Khan transferred the capital to Murshidabad. (After the Battle of Plassey, the East India Company transferred the capital to Calcutta, which also became the capital of India.). All these capitals were situated on the banks of rivers keeping in view the geography of the country and communication facilities, the capitals were not only the administrative headquarters but also military cantonments and trade centers. Akbar also introduced a well-defined

and efficient administrative machinery for the provinces. The head of the province was the governor, styled Sipah-Salar in the days of Akbar, Subahdar under Jahangir and Shah Jahan and Nazim under Aurangzeb and his successors. He was the vicegerent of the emperor in the province and was responsible for executive matters, defence, criminal justice and general supervision of the province. Below the Subahdar, but not subordinate to him, was the Diwan appointed by and responsible to the central government for revenue administration and civil justice. These two officers, Subahdar and Diwan shared responsibility for the whole provincial government. They were assisted by other provincial officers, bakhshi (pay master of the army), Sadr (head of religious department, charity and grant), Qazi (judge), Kotwal (superintendent of police), Mir-bahr (admiral) and the Waqianavis (news reporter). The province or Subah was divided into Sarkars and Parganas or Mahals. The sarkar was both an administrative and revenue unit, headed by a Faujdar in the executive and administrative department and amalguzar or amil or bitikchi for revenue administration. In the Parganah or mahal, Shiqdar was the executive officer and Amin was responsible for collection of revenues. Other officers were Qunungos (literary the expounders of law but in practice the keepers of land-revenue records) and Patwaris who were clerks or writers in the Parganah. Though the administrative and revenue functions were separate and well-defined, officers of one branch were made responsible to go to the aid of those of other branch in times of need, i.e. they were made to work in harmony and co-operation. The above basic principles of administration continued throughout the Mughal period.

For proper administration, Bengal (Subah Bangalah) was divided into 19 Sarkars and 682 Parganas or Mahals. Land-revenue was the main source of income, so the Mughals first paid attention to the reform of the revenue administration. The revenue system was also reformed in the reign of Akbar, when Raja Todar Mal introduced his *bandobast* or Settlement in 1582. This was, however, paper work, because at that time, the major portion of Bengal was outside Mughal control. Even Chittagong which came under the Mughal control 84 years later was included in the Settlement. It is therefore, presumed that Todar Mal copied the revenue figures prevailing in the pre-Mughal period, i.e. under the Independent Sultans. The revenues were divided into Mal and Sayer, Mal was the name given to the land-revenue, while Sayer included all kinds of revenues (like customs duties, and other sundry duties) except the land revenues. Lands were also divided into Khalsa and Jagir for the purpose of revenue collection, Khalsa lands were those which were directly administered by the government through the Diwan and his staff; the Jagir lands were those which were assigned to the officers, civil or military, for their services, i.e., they were paid in Jagirs. In the later period lands were also assigned to establishments, like the Nawwara (navy), Kheda (catching elephants), Amlah-I-Asham (or military establishment for guarding the frontier). Lands were also granted to religious persons and learned

men, as a means of subsistence they were endowed with lands for their maintenance. An important feature of the revenue administration was the existence of zamindars, who acted as middlemen between the Ryot and the Government. The Jagirdars also collected revenue through the zamindars. The collection of revenue was not a great problem for the government. The main problem was the fixing of revenue to be collected from the ryots and the amount to be paid by the collectors/zamindars to the government exchequer. The Diwan and his staff remained busy settling the issues keeping in view the condition of the lands, the loss of crops due to weather conditions and the land erosion caused by flood, change of course of the river, transformation of agricultural lands to fallow ones, or bringing fallow lands under the plough. The Diwani department also decided cases where taqvi or agricultural loans had to be provided. The Mughal revenue system was, therefore, designed to achieve the object of collecting as much revenue as possible and also keeping the ryots happy and content, so that they might prosper and bring more and more land under the plough. The Mughal revenue system was so well thought out and well planned that the system, with no great change continued through the British period.

In the early Muslim period, Bengal was designated in the court circle as Balghakpur or rebel province, because the governors of Bengal shook off the tutelage of Delhi whenever they found an opportunity. Bengal being far away from Delhi, it would take a long time to deal with them. The Sultans of Delhi tried to solve the problem by dividing Bengal into smaller units, Sher Shah, for example, divided Bengal into 19 Sarkars. They were smaller units so that they would not dare raising their head against the Sultan. There was one provincial governor (called at that time Hakim), but he was shorn of military power, he was only a co-ordinator among the Sarkars. The Mughals solved this problem by appointing as Subahdars (nazims) the royal princes, near relatives of the emperor and trusted high officials. There is no example of provincial governors revolting against the emperors. These royal princes, Shah Shuja, Shahzada Muhammad Azam and Shahzada Azim-ud-din (Azim-ush-shan) occupied the Subahdari of Bengal for nearly forty years, of the near relatives Raja Man Singh (related to Akbar through his Rajput Queen), Ibrahim Khan (Nur Jahan's brother), Azam Khan (Shuja's father-in-law), Shaista Khan (Aurangzeb's maternal uncle) ruled faithfully again for about forty years. Shaista Khan alone was in Bengal for more than twenty years. The Kokas or foster brothers of the emperors also served in Bengal faithfully. In this connection, the Chishti family of Fatehpur-Sikri, about 23 miles from Agra, deserves special mention. Akbar was very much devoted to Shaikh Salim Chishti of Fatehpur-Sikri; Prince Salim (emperor Jahangir) was born in the Khanqah of Shaikh Salim and it is believed that, the prince was born with his blessings; Prince Salim was a play-mate of the grandchildren of the saint, and Akbar built the city and the fort of Fatehpur-Sikri in his honour. Jahangir appointed three members of this family as governors

of Bengal. They were Qutbud-din Khan Koka, Islam Khan Chishti and Qasim Khan Chishti. Islam Khan Chishti made a great name for himself by subjugating Bengal.

After the death of Aurangzeb, though there was hardly any structural change, qualitative changes took place in the administration of Bengal. One of the causes, probably the chief cause of the downfall of the Mughal Empire, was the several wars of succession and rebellion of the princes against the emperor. Jahangir revolted against his father, Khusru and Shah Jahan revolted against their father, but the wars of succession among the sons of Shah Jahan (even before the latter's death) and those after the death of Aurangzeb and Shah Alam Bahadur Shah struck at the very foundation of the empire. The wars were not waged against the external foes, but they were internal warfare; brothers fought against brothers, the Mughals fought against the Mughals. The result was the loss of army, life and property and the cumulative effect was that the empire became weak and reached the verge of ruin. At last it so happened that after the death of Shah Alam Bahadur Shah (1712) there was a dearth of qualified and efficient officers, generals, army chiefs and civil servants. The later Mughal emperors being weak, there was chaos, confusion and indiscipline in every branch of the administration. The effects were also felt in the provinces. The provincial officers, the subahdar (nazim), the diwan and their lower officers were sent from the centre, but now the flow of officers from the centre stopped. The provinces began to shake off the authority of the centre one by one. In these circumstances, the Nawabi period in Bengal began. Murshid Quli Khan was the last imperial officer, coming from the center and appointed by the emperor. From his time, though nominally, Bengal was under the authority of the Mughal emperors, and the imperial revenues were being sent regularly, practically the emperor gave up interfering in provincial matters. The Nazims (as they were called then) were independent in administration, except that, for expediency's sake, they owed allegiance to the emperor and sent imperial revenues to Delhi.

There was another development in Bengal. As the flow of officers from the center was stopped, the Nazims had to promote lower officers, and in this process the efficient experienced Hindu officers went up the ladder in the administration. They learnt Persian, the official language and mastered the art of administration and working of all branches of the secretariat. In Murshid Quli Khan's time the chief Qanungos were Darpa Narayan and Krishna Narayan; the chief of the mint was Raghunandan. This last named person exerted so much influence that he grabbed zamindari of a large area in several districts in the name of his brother Ramjivan. In Murshid Quli Khan's time again, there were 16 big zamindars collecting revenues from 615 Parganahs; smaller zamindars and taluqdars collected revenues from another 1600 Parganah. Big zamindars were almost all Hindus, 75% of the smaller zamindars and taluqdars were also Hindus.

Later the Hindus also occupied the high post of Diwan and Naib-Nazim. Families and persons holding the family title of Sarkar, Bakhshi, Dastidar, Qanungo, Chakladar, Tarafdar, Laskar, Halidar etc. may trace their origin from the Nawabi period, when their forefathers used to hold those offices. In Shuja-ud-din's time Alam Chand was the Diwan. He was given the title of Rai Rayan, and was so much in the confidence of the Nawab that he was a member of the advisory council. In the time of Alivardi Khan prominent Hindu officers were Janakiram, Durlabhram, Kiritchand, Ummid Rai, Biru Dutta, Ramram Singh and Gokul Chand. In Siraj-ud-dowla's time Nand Kumar, Omi Chand came to prominence and Rajballabh not only came to prominence but also started a conspiracy against the Nawab. With the growth of trade and commerce came the Marwari banking families from upper India who started their banking houses. Fateh Chand the first holder of the title "Jagat Seth", did his money-lending business in Bengal with the patronage of Murshid Quli Khan. On his recommendation, Fateh Chand got the title of Jagat Seth from the emperor. His successor, Mahtab Chand Jagat Seth fanned the conspiracy against Siraj-ud-dowla in 1757.

The Muslim rulers of Bengal, the Sultans or the Mughals were all foreigners; they all came from Central Asia. But while the Sultans came burning their boats to stay permanently in the land of their domicile, the Mughals did not think of making Bengal their home. None of the Sultans is known to have left the country; they lie buried here. Of the Mughal emperors only Humayun came to Bengal and stayed at Gaur for about six months, the rebel prince Shah Jahan stayed at Dhaka only for about a week. Even the Mughal high officials, Subahdar, Diwan etc. are not known to have made Bengal their homes after their active service. The situation was, however, different in the Nawabi period. Whereas, in the Sultanate period Bengal's cultural contact with the outside Muslim world was limited to chiefly Makka and Madina, in the Mughal period such connections, particularly with Arabia, Iran and Turkey increased in a large way.

The Mughal emperors were learned and liberal and they possessed high moral principles. The high officers, like Wazir, Subahdar, Diwan etc. were also very learned and cultured people, they set the examples of etiquette, tradition and polished manner to be emulated by others. Some of the Subahdars of Bengal were Persian poets, Qasim Khan Juyuni and Shaista Khan were famous for the poetical compositions. The Subahdars maintained libraries in their residences, and got books on history, philosophy, science and belles letters copied by calligraphists. Prince Azim-ud-din is known to have had discussions in learned assemblies. Masnavi of Maulana Rumi was favourite reading in such assemblies. There were poets among soldiers and officers who composed and recited poems in private gatherings to make the occasions lively. Poets also accompanied the campaigns and composed tales of victory in Persian verse.

The Muslims came to Bengal from outside from the beginning, but with the consolidation of Mughal authority, there was peace, and prospects of

employment opportunities increased. So scholarly Muslims, i.e., those who pursued peaceful life, like the Ulama, Sufis, Teachers, Poets and Physicians came to Bengal in large numbers. In the Sultanate period, the Sunni Muslims were predominant in Bengal; the Mughals were also Sunnis, but many of their officers came from Iran, so the Shiaism from Iran penetrated into Bengal. The Shias first came to Bengal in large number from the time of Jahangir, in the train of his Shia Subahdar Ibrahim Khan Fatehjang (brother of Nur Jahan) Shah Shuja was a Sunni, but his mother (Momtaz Mahal) and his wife and his father-in-law were Shia; his tutor was also a Shia. That is why we find that in his time at Dhaka and Rajmahal there were many Shia divines, teachers and physicians. Murshid Quli Khan, who is the founder of the Nizamat in Bengal, belonged to the Shia faith (though originally he was the son of a Brahmin, brought up by a Muslim, an Iarian Shia), his successor Subahdars were also Shias. So from the time of the Battle of Plassey, the Shias were prominent in the Muslim society of particularly the cities like Dhaka, Murshidabad, Hugli, and Patna. The Muslim Ulama (sunnis and shias alike), not only joined government service according to their training, but they mostly devoted themselves to teaching. Some of them were also physicians; with the prospect of good business, some physicians also came from Delhi and other parts of India to Bengal. No contemporary history for the Sultanate Period was written in Bengal (at least no such book has so far been available), but in the Mughal period there is no dearth of such history books. Abdul Latif wrote a diary of the day to day account of his sojourn from Rajmahal to Ghoraghat in the train of Subahdar Islam Khan Chishti; Mirza Nathan (Shitab Khan) wrote 'Baharistan-I-Ghaibi', giving the account of subjugation of Bengal by Islam Khan Chishti; Muhammad Masum, wrote about the war of succession between the sons of Shah Jahan; it was a contemporary account under the title "Tarik-I-Shah Shuja" and Shihab-ud-din Talish wrote his "Fathiya-i-Ibariya" or 'Tarikh-I-Asham' giving his account of Mir Jumla's conquest of Assam and Kamrup. Talish accompanied Mir Jumla on the campaigns. The same author also wrote an account of the conquest of Chittagong by Shaista Khan. Mirza Lutfullah, son-in-law of Shuj-ud-din Muhammad Khan (entitled successively Murshid Quli Khan and Rustam Jang), and a deputy Subahdar successively of Dhaka and Orissa, was a good poet; his poetical surname was Mukhmur. Yusuf Ali Khan, son-in-law of Nawab Sarfaraz Khan, wrote his history entitled Ahwal-i-Mahabat Jungi (affairs of Alivardi Khan). The Munshis or secretaries of the Nawabs were learned in Persian style and diction. Some of them wrote histories at the beginning of English rule.

The Persian being the official language, the Hindus in Bengal (as also in India) learnt the language to obtain state services. Persian also influenced the Bengali language and literature in a great way. Many Persian words entered the Bengali vocabulary and many such words are still found not only in literature but also in the court circle and in the day to day use of the people. Contemporary Bengali

literature composed by the Hindus was religion-based. It was written to glorify the Gods and Goddesses; non-religious or secular literature was totally absent. But being influenced by the Persian literature, poems dealing with love stories of men and women began to be theme of Bengali literature. Persian literary works, particularly romantic stories were translated into Bengali. Side by side Bengali literature was also influenced by Hindi-Awadhi poetical works. Muslims began to write Bengali poetical works from the 16 century. Poets like Sayyid Sultan, Muhammad Khan, Daulat Qazi and Alaol earned good name as Bengali poets. The last two flourished at Mrohaung, capital of Arakan in the 17<sup>th</sup> century. Bengali Muslim poets also wrote Faqiri, Darveshi and Baul songs. They influenced the Hindu poets also, and the Bauls and Baul songs particularly influenced the Hindus, Marsia songs also became very popular after the coming of the Shias.

Under the Mughals, particularly in the Nawabi period, there was an enormous growth of Muslim society in Bengal. In the Sultanate period foreign Muslims, like the Arabs, the Turks and the Afghans were predominant, Iranians also came, but their number was small. They belonged mostly to the upper class society. The foreign Muslims again belonged to four main groups — the Sayyids, the Shaikhs, the Pathans (Afghans) and the Mughals. Some of the non-Muslims, Hindus or Buddhists and the worshippers of local deities accepted Islam, but the case of conversion increased largely in the Mughal period. The lower class non-Muslims accepted Islam either for mundane reasons, like gaining favours from the rulers, or getting state services, or they were attracted by the teaching of Islam. The Saints and Darvishes spread over the outlying area, their activities also helped to increase conversion. The Saints were generally very learned people, they lived a simple and unostentatious life and thus attracted the people.

Among the Hindus, the Brahmins, the Vaidyas and the Kayasthas were predominant. The Kshatriyas are not generally met with in Bengal. The caste system was very much prevalent. The Brahmins not only belonged to the superior caste, but they also controlled the society. They presided over all social and religious functions, they were the most educated, most learned people in the society. They accepted the profession of teaching and supplied *Purohits* and *Pandits* to teach religious principles and to conduct worship. They administered the temples and they taught religious scriptures like the Vedas and the Upanishads. The Brahmins were divided into various classes, they were known by Gains, i.e. places of residence. A 16<sup>th</sup> century Bengali poet, Mukanda Ram in his Chandi Mangal Kavya gives the names of 40 such Gains, such as Chatuti, Mukhti, Bindya, Kanjilal, Ganguli, Ghoshal, Putitundu, Matilal, Baral, Piplai, Paldhi and Mastak. Such titles are still used by the Bengali Brahmins, and some of the important of them are Chattapadhaya, Bandopadhyaya, Gangopadhaya (Ganguli), Mukhopadhyaya etc. Vaidyas also belonged to the high society. They adopted various profession, but they were chiefly physicians.

They adopted titles like Sen, Gupta, Das, Datta and Kar etc. The Kayasthas were professionals and they adopted trade and business as their profession. They were also the writers or Clerks and Shopkeepers. Their prominent titles were Ghose, Basu and Mitra, but they also adopted other titles like Pal, Palit, Nandi, Singh, Sen, Dev, Datta, Das, Kar, Nag, Shome, Chanda, Bhanja, Vishnu, Raha, Bindu etc. The lowest strata of society were the Sudras, the untouchables; they had no right to enter the temple or read or touch religious texts. These untouchables entered into the fold of Islam to save themselves from the oppression of the higher castes.

The Hindus were particular in receiving education and giving education to their children. They were able to adapt themselves to new situations during the Muslim rule. They learnt the Persian language, but when the English established their authority, they began to learn the English language. But they did not neglect learning Bengali and reading their religious texts, written in Sanskrit. They had two types of educational institutions, Toll for educating boys and girls in "the 3 r's" (reading, writing and arithmetic) and Chatuspati which were institutions of higher learning, reading Smriti and Sruti literature, the Vedas, the Puranas and the Upanishads. Female education was prevalent. Muslims had their Maktabas and Madrasas, the former for elementary and the latter for higher education. The mosques also served as schools for teaching the children. Muslim family life, birth, death, marriages etc. were regulated by their religious tenets. The females were honoured in the family. They were mistresses but among both the Hindus and the Muslims polygamy was prevalent. Muslims could not marry more than four at time but among the Hindus, the Kulins had no such restrictions. Burning of the Satis (burning widows with the dead husbands) was prevalent. Sometimes they were burnt forcibly. The Caste system was prevalent. Teachers of the society (the Brahmins) enforced caste rules very strictly.

The great Vaishnava teacher Shri Chaitanya Deva was born in Nabadvipa (Nadia) and flourished in the first half of the 16<sup>th</sup> century. He preached in Bengal and in the neighbouring area. He challenged caste superiority and preached the principle of equality among human beings. His teaching gained great popularity among the people in the Mughal period. Nabadvip became the center of learning and famous Sanskrit teachers devoted themselves to the study, and writing of Smriti and Sruti literature, and schools of thought grew and developed in that place. A huge literature centering round the life and teachings of Chaitanya Deva grew and developed and various authors wrote a great number of books. Literature also developed round the local deities, Manasa, Chandi, Kalika etc. and this literature came to be known as Manasa Mangal, Chandi Mangal, Kalika Mangal, etc.

Bengali language got literary status in the Sultanate period. Famous literary works, Sri Krishna Kirtana of Chandidas, Ramayana of Krittivasa Ujha, Sri Krishna Vijaya of Maladhar Vasu Gunaraj Khan, Mahabharata of Kavindr

Paremeshwar were written by Hindu poets. But towards the end of the Sultanate period, the Muslims also began to write Bengali poems. A large number of books were written in the Mughal period, books on the Ramayana, Mahabharata, Mangal Kavyas and Chaitayna Kavyas. The Muslims under the influence of Persian literature, introduced romantic literature. Apart from these great literary works, folk poetry composed by village bards has also been collected in large numbers. These were sung in social gatherings in leisure hours, by both Hindus and Muslims. All these were romantic tales, but some of them were based on historical events.

The Mughals were foreigners. They drained Bengal's treasures to their capitals, but Mughal rule was also a blessing for Bengal. They established peace, good government and discipline, freed the people from the oppression of the pirates. The people prospered and their literary activities got momentum. As the Mughals were liberal in religious matters, the non-Muslims could also practice their religion freely without any interference. In the words of Sir Jadunath Sarkar, "The period of imperial Mughal rule over Bengal witnessed the working of certain new forces which have completely transformed Bengali life and thought and whose influence is still operating in the province."

## References

- J. N. Sarkar ed. - *History of Bengal*, Vol. II, Dhaka University, 1948.  
 A. Karim - *History of Bengal*, Mughal Period, Vol., I, I.B.S., Rajshahi University, 1992.  
 A. Karim - *History of Bengal*, Mughal Period, Vol. II, I.B.S., Rajshahi University, 1995.  
 K. M. Karim - *The provinces of Bihar and Bengal under Shahjahan*, A.S.B., Dhaka, 1947.  
 A. Karim - *Murshid Quli Khan and His Times*, A.S.B., Dhaka, 1963.  
 A. Karim - *Dacca the Mughal Capital*, A.S.B., Dhaka, 1964.  
 T.K. Ray Chowdhury - *Bengal under Akbar and Jahangir*, Delhi, 1968.  
 Ramesh Chandra Majumdar - *Bangladesher Ithihas*, Madhya Juga, 4<sup>th</sup> edition, Calcutta, 1987.  
 Abdul Karim - *Banglar Ithihas, Mughal Amal*, Vol. I, IBS, Rajshahi, 1992.  
 Abdul Karim - *Banglar Ithihas (1200-1857)*, Dhaka, 1999.

## List of Sipah Salars/Subahdars/Nazims of Bengal

| No. | Name                      | Year        |
|-----|---------------------------|-------------|
| 1.  | Mumin Khan                | 1574 – 1575 |
| 2.  | Khan Jahan                | 1575 – 1578 |
| 3.  | Muzaffar Khan Turbati     | 1579 – 1580 |
|     | Rebel Government          | 1580 – 1582 |
| 4.  | Khan Azam Mirza Aziz Koka | 1582 – 1583 |
| 5.  | Shahbaz Khan              | 1583 – 1585 |
| 6.  | Sadiq Khan                | 1585 – 1586 |
| 7.  | Wazir Khan                | 1586 – 1587 |

| No. | Name                                                                      | Year                     |
|-----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| 8.  | Said Khan                                                                 | 1587 - 1594              |
| 9.  | Man Singh                                                                 | 1594 - 1606              |
| 10. | Qutbud-din Khan Koka                                                      | 1606 - 1607              |
| 11. | Jahangir Quli Beg                                                         | 1607 - 1608              |
| 12. | Islam Khan Chishti                                                        | 1608 - 1613              |
| 13. | Quasim Khan Chishti                                                       | 1613 - 1617              |
| 14. | Ibrahim Khan Fatehjang                                                    | 1617 - 1624              |
|     | Rebel Prince Shahjahan's Subahdar Darab Khan                              | 1624 - 1625              |
| 15. | Mahabat Khan                                                              | 1625 - 1626              |
| 16. | Mukarram Khan                                                             | 1626 - 1627              |
| 17. | Fidai Khan                                                                | 1627 - 1628              |
| 18. | Quasim Khan Juynni                                                        | 1628 - 1632              |
| 19. | Azam Khan                                                                 | 1632 - 1635              |
| 20. | Islam Khan Mashhadi                                                       | 1635 - 1639              |
| 21. | Prince Muhammad Shuja                                                     | 1639 - 1660              |
| 22. | Mir Jumla Muazzam Khan                                                    | 1660 - 1663              |
| 23. | Shaista Khan                                                              | 1663 - 1678; 1679 - 1688 |
| 24. | Azam Khan Koka                                                            | 1678                     |
| 25. | Prince Muhammad Azam                                                      | 1678 - 1679              |
| 26. | Khan Jahan                                                                | 1688 - 1689              |
| 27. | Ibrahim Khan                                                              | 1689 - 1698              |
| 28. | Prince Muhammad Azim-ud-din                                               | 1698 - 1712              |
| 29. | Prince Farkhunda Suiyar (He was infant, Murshid Quli Khan was his Deputy) | 1712 - 1713              |
| 30. | Mir Jumla Ubaidullah (In absentia, Murshid Quli Khan was his deputy)      | 1713 - 1716              |
| 31. | Murshid Quli Jafar Khan                                                   | 1716 - 1727              |
| 32. | Shuja-ud-din Muhammad Khan                                                | 1729 - 1739              |
| 33. | Sarfaraz Khan                                                             | 1739 - 1740              |
| 34. | Alivardi Khan (Mahabat Jang)                                              | 1740 - 1756              |
| 35. | Siraj-ud-Daula                                                            | 1756 - 1757              |